Judicial Practices and Procedures
(last modified April 16, 2026)

Leatha D. Mullins, Judge
Alison Mendoza, Judicial Assistant

Contact Information
Mailing Address: Courtroom A, Okeechobee County Courthouse, 312 NW 3rd Street, Okeechobee, FL 34972
Physical Address: Courtroom A, Okeechobee County Courthouse, 312 NW 3rd Street, Okeechobee, FL 34972
Telephone: 863-763-1240
E-mail: OCJudge2@Circuit19.org

Table of Contents
A. Communications with the Judicial Office 1
B. Scheduling Procedures 2
C. Remote Appearance 7
D. Submission of Orders and Judgments 8
E. Courtesy Copies of Case Law and Other Documents 8
F. Emergency and Other Urgent Matters 9
G. Exhibits for Evidentiary Proceedings 9
H. Pretrial Procedures and Conferences 9
I. Setting Case for Trial 10
J. Forms 10
K. Other Division Procedures 10

A. Communications with the Judicial Office

- **Method of Communication:** OCJudge2@Circuit19.org (Email is the preferred method of communication and will be responded to promptly). The subject line must contain the case number, case name, and relevant matter (e.g., 2025 DR 001234 – Doe v. Doe - 2-Hour Hearing Requested.) Phone contact is also permitted at the phone number listed above.

- **Ex parte Communications:** All communications with the judicial office must comply with Canon 3 of the Code of Judicial Conduct, which prohibits a judge from initiating, permitting, or considering ex parte communications and from considering other communications outside the presence of the parties concerning a pending or impending proceeding, unless authorized by law. All parties must be copied on any e-mail directed

to the judicial office, unless an ex parte communication is authorized by law.

- **Unsolicited Communications:** Unsolicited communications from non-parties will not be considered by the court. Parties may only contact the judicial office in accordance with these practices and procedures.

- **E-Filing Portal Contact Information:** All attorneys and self-represented litigants must provide an e-mail address to receive signed orders electronically, unless excused. Fla. R. Gen. Prac. & Jud. Admin. 2.516. It is the responsibility of attorneys and self-represented litigants to update their contact information using Form 2.603 any time there is a change in the e-mail account registered for electronic service.

- **Orders Submitted/Entered in Court:** Orders entered in open court are not e-filed or e-served by this office. The original order will be filed by the Clerk of Court. You must bring sufficient copies for conforming by the Clerk. You are responsible for providing copies to all parties, whether by conformed copy in open court or by U.S. Mail or eservice.

- **Response to Inquiries:** All inquiries will be responded to in a timely manner. Please do not send multiple e-mails on the same issue/same inquiry. E-mails will be responded to as soon as possible.

- **Other Communication Procedures:** No party or attorney shall otherwise communicate directly to the Court.

B. Scheduling Procedures

- **Court Schedule:** All hearings must be coordinated with opposing counsel. Failure to do so will result in the motion being stricken from the court's docket. The notice of hearing must reflect the hearing was coordinated and the amount of time reserved. All motions must be filed with the Clerk prior to scheduling a motion for hearing. Family UMC are only for hearings that require 10 minutes or less and can be scheduled using the Court's online scheduling system. Do not schedule on Special Set Hearing time slots. Time reserved for hearings will be strictly enforced. 5-10 minutes hearings must be scheduled at least 5 business days prior to the hearing date (unless agreed by all parties to schedule sooner, the parties must then contact the JA). The Court's calendars are posted online at https://slccjis.stlucieco.gov/attorney_calendar (instructions on scheduling are below). All hearings scheduled online must be cancelled online by noon the day before the hearing if not going forward. A notice of cancellation should also be e-filed (with a copy sent to OCJudge2@circuit19.org). Failure to coordinate hearing time and failure

to timely cancel a hearing may result in the loss of your online scheduling privileges. If you have any questions regarding these procedures, please do not hesitate to email: OCJudge2@circuit19.org. If you have a matter that is time sensitive and there is no time available on the online calendar, you may contact the JA for assistance in scheduling the matter for hearing. Please do not contact the JA about scheduling an earlier time unless opposing counsel is in agreement and you have reviewed these procedures and the online calendar/schedule.

- **OVERVIEW**: Okeechobee Family Court is generally conducted 1 week per month (the 1st week of the month). Family Uniform Motion Calendar is usually on Wednesday during Family Week from 9:30-10:30 a.m. and Domestic Violence Hearings are generally on Tuesday at 11:30 a.m. and are set by the Court. Other dates may be utilized on an "as needed" basis at the Court's discretion. Please be sure to review the online calendar regularly.

- **Scheduling Hearings via the online calendar:**

1. **All Hearings must be cleared with opposing counsel.** Good faith cooperation is expected from counsel and their support staff. Should counsel or their staff fail to respond within 3 business days, or refuse to cooperate in obtaining, or in setting a hearing, the difficulty should be specifically set forth - either in the motion or in the notice of hearing - and the hearing can then be set unilaterally – giving opposing counsel at least five (5) business days' notice of the hearing date (for 5-10 minute motions only). Fifteen (15) business days' notice of the hearing if over 10 minutes reserved. Failure to set out, with specificity, the difficulty of scheduling when unilaterally setting a hearing will result in the hearing being stricken by the Court.

2. **Special Request by Counsel for earlier hearing date – when time is not available on the online calendar***:* If the parties agree that a hearing on a time sensitive issue is needed, and there is no time available on the online calendar, please contact the JA for assistance in scheduling the matter for hearing (e-mail OCJudge2@circuit19.org). Please state clearly in the email that there is no time available via the online calendar within the timeframe the parties are looking for, and the parties are jointly inquiring about earlier dates, per procedures. The email must state the parties agree the matter requires an earlier date and the amount of time needed. You should not send multiple requests for the same issue - the JA will respond in a timely manner, as quickly as possible.

3. **If scheduling a Motion**, the Motion must be filed prior to scheduling a hearing.

4. **Pro-Se/Self Represented Parties:** Petitioners and/or Respondents without an attorney are "pro se." If both parties are pro se/self-represented, they will be referred to the Pro Se Case Manager. If you are self-represented and wish to inquire about your case status or are looking to schedule a hearing, you may complete a Form A or B (as applicable) at www.circuit19.org, under Family Court Information and Resources. If you have a working/viable email address that you wish to use for e-service, please fill out a form and file it with the Clerk of Court. You will be served with copies via your eservice address.

5. **Default Final Hearings**: The hearing is in-person and should be scheduled on the Court's regular motion calendar, not on the Court's UMC. The Final Hearing should be scheduled for fifteen minutes to one hour, depending on the issues involved via the online calendar. If there is no physical evidence and only testimony is required, then default hearings may be scheduled via zoom. Once a notice of hearing has been filed, the moving party must provide the Court with a proposed Order Setting Trial/Final Hearing After Default and provide a self-addressed stamped envelope for the defaulted party (via US Mail or Courthouse Box delivery) if an email has not been registered. The form Order Setting the final hearing is available on the Court's website. See, Korman v. Shapiro, ___ So. 3d ____, 2024 WL 1543216 (Fla. 3rd DCA 2024). They must be noticed 30 days prior to the hearing date.

6. **ADOPTIONS FINAL HEARINGS** are in-person and should be scheduled on the Court's regular motion calendar, not on the Court's UMC. The Final Hearing should be scheduled for fifteen minutes to one hour, depending on the issues involved.

7. **UNCONTESTED PETITIONS FOR DISSOLUTION OF MARRIAGE**: If set for Final Hearing, please schedule on the Court's UMC docket. Please provide a copy of the agreement (including child support worksheet - if applicable), a copy of one of the party's driver's license/State ID, and an agreed upon final judgment. Or, you may file affidavits of the parties waiving a final hearing (form available on this website). Please provide the affidavits, copy of the agreement(s), parenting plans, child support guidelines, etc. and proposed Final Judgment (in Word Format) via email to the Court. If all is in correct form, a Final Judgment will be issued and e-filed.

8. If you are scheduling a Final Hearing, or providing the aforementioned affidavit(s), you must verify that both parties have filed all of the required documents for the hearing to take place. Failure to comply will result in the hearing being stricken from the hearing docket.

9. **INJUNCTION FOR PROTECTION HEARINGS**: (all types) may not be scheduled using the Online Calendar. These hearings are set/scheduled by the court, not by the parties and cannot be cancelled or continued without a court order. You must file a motion and submit with a proposed order to the court. Injunction for Protection Hearings (all types) must be conducted in-person.

10. **UNIFORM MOTION CALENDAR (UMC)**: Hearings may be scheduled using the online calendaring system, UMC hearings are generally conducted on Wednesday during Family Week from 9:30-10:30 a.m. Prior to setting a matter on the Uniform Motion Calendar (UMC), the party or attorney noticing the motion shall attempt to resolve the matter and shall, in the Notice of Hearing, certify what attempts have been made to resolve the issue without the need for a hearing and the outcome of those attempts.

Hearings on the UMC are limited to ten (10) minutes or less per case (not per motion), five (5) minutes for each side and only non-evidentiary motions will be heard on the UMC. Pursuant to Administrative Order 2015-12, Civil Contempt, Temporary Relief and non-routine evidentiary matters shall not be heard at UMC.

The moving party shall furnish the Judge by email to OCJudge2@circuit19.org, a copy of the Motion to be heard, the Notice of Hearing and a Proposed Order in WORD format, at least five (5) business days in advance of the date of the scheduled hearing.

11. **Online Calendar**:

a. Log on to https://slccjis.stlucieco.gov/attorney_calendar You must register to obtain your user id and password on the site; any issues relating to your login and/or use of the online calendar should be directed to: circuit19.org).

b. Click on case Scheduling;

c. Enter County, Judge Mullins' name, month & year in drop down fields;

d. Click Available Hearing Time: View button and a screen will open showing all available hearing times – keep in mind hearing time may go quickly and multiple dates should be coordinated in case the first date is no longer available. Hearing time cannot and should not be reserved;

e. Choose available dates/time slot.

f. The Case Type is the Full Name of the Motion(s) being set for hearing (M to Compel, M for Mediation, CMC; etc.); the Case Number is 25DRXXXXA & 25DRXXXA (enter all case numbers as needed); the style is

Petitioner v Respondent—you must add the full name (First and Last) of the parties.

g. Any issues relating to your login and/or use of the online calendar should be directed to: circuit19.org).

- **Notice of Hearing:** After filing a notice of hearing with the Clerk, a copy of the Notice of Hearing, along with the Motion must be immediately forwarded to the JA via e-mail to OCJudge2@circuit19.org. Should a notice of hearing not be forwarded to the Judicial Assistant, the hearing may not be placed on the Court's docket.

- **Submission Deadlines:** Any materials that you would like the judge to consider prior to a hearing, including case law, memoranda of law, or evidence agreed to by opposing counsel, may be emailed to OCJudge2@circuit19.org in advance of the hearing and copied to opposing counsel. Do not assume that if you have filed a memorandum or response that the Judge will review it, it must be emailed to OCJudge2@circuit9.org with the case number and date of the hearing so that the Judge may have sufficient time to review.

- **Order of Proceedings:** Matters will be heard in the order they appear on the docket unless a special request is made to be called first, last etc.

- **Continuance Procedure:** Motions to Continue should be e-filed and a copy, along with a proposed order (in WORD format) forwarded to the Judicial Assistant at OCJudge2@circuit19.org, no later than Noon the day prior to the hearing date.

- **Cancelling Hearings:** All hearings scheduled online must be cancelled online by noon the day before the hearing if not going forward. A notice of cancellation should also be e-filed (with a copy sent to OCJudge2@circuit19.org). If a special set hearing is cancelled, an email to OCJudge2@circuit19.org, along with a notice of cancellation must be sent as soon as possible.

- **HEARINGS THAT REQUIRE ONE (1) HOUR OR LESS**: Schedule hearings that require one (1) hour or less using the Court's online calendaring system. The moving party shall furnish the Judge by email to OCJudge2@circuit19.org, a copy of the Motion to be heard, the Notice of Hearing and a Proposed Order in WORD format, at least five (5) business days in advance of the date of the scheduled hearing.
  You may schedule all matters, including evidentiary matters that require one (1) hour or less using this system. Additional motions may not be "piggy-backed" by cross-notice unless counsel first confirms with opposing counsel and/or the judicial assistant that sufficient additional

time can be reserved to hear them. You may not schedule multiple hearings in the same case on the same day exceeding one (1) hour.

- **TEMPORARY RELIEF HEARINGS**: Parties must attend mediation before a Temporary Relief Hearing may be set. If you schedule a Temporary Relief Hearing without first having been to mediation, your motion will not be heard and your hearing will be stricken from the Court's Docket. All temporary relief hearings will be scheduled for a maximum of 30 minutes. You may ask permission via email to extend a hearing to a maximum of one hour with good cause shown. If a temporary is set for more than 30 minutes without court permission it will be stricken.

- **HEARINGS THAT REQUIRE MORE THAN ONE (1) HOUR**: Contact the Judicial Assistant by email at OCJudge2@circuit19.org to obtain hearing dates and times to coordinate with the opposing party. A copy of the motion must be attached to your email. Pursuant to Administrative Order 2015-12, unless otherwise determined by the Court, any party who seeks to schedule a trial or hearing on any contested issue, other than contempt, injunctions against domestic or repeat violence, or Title IV-D actions, which will take more than one (1) hour, SHALL FIRST PARTICIPATE IN MEDIATION. See Administrative Order 2015-12 for additional information. Additional motions may not be "piggy-backed" by cross-notice unless counsel first confirms with opposing counsel and/or the judicial assistant that sufficient additional time can be reserved to hear them.

- **MOTIONS TO WITHDRAW-Rule 2.505 (f) (1) Fla. R. Jud. Admin.:** The motion must contain the client's last known address, phone number, including area code and e-service address (if available). If not available, the motion must state, not available. ***Additionally, the motion must set forth the next court date or that there are no future court dates. If set for trial, the motion must state the date of trial.*** **If a consent by the client has been filed and referenced in the Motion to Withdraw, a hearing is not required. You may submit a copy of the motion and consent with a proposed order in WORD. Please be sure that you follow the Court's posted procedures for submitting proposed order to this office OCJudge2@circuit19.org. Note: If the consent is obtained after the motion has been filed, you must file an amended motion referencing the consent.**

C. Remote Appearance

- **ZOOM VIDEO**: Uniform Motion Calendars, Case Management Conferences and Non-Evidentiary Hearings one hour or less are via Zoom Video (see Zoom Information below), unless otherwise directed by

the Court.

- **IN-PERSON**: Attendance at all Trials and Evidentiary Hearings, and all Injunction for Protection Hearings are in-person.

- Attendance at Default Hearing are in person unless a properly filed motion to appear virtually has been filed and approved.

- **Platform Used:** Zoom

- **Platform Meeting ID#:** Meeting ID: 339 747 0884 Link: https://zoom.us/j/3397470884 (see attached for complete Zoom information)

- **Requirements:** : If you wish to appear remotely, you must file a motion and remote appearances must be in accordance with Rule 2.530.

- **Technology Needs:** The attorney is responsible for providing the Zoom link to his or her client or witness and must be prepared with digital copies of evidence if necessary for the hearing.

D. Submission of Orders and Judgments

- **Format:** All Proposed Orders must be submitted in WORD format.

- **Submission Method:** OCJudge2@circuit19.org

- **Deadline for Submissions:** 5-business days prior to the scheduled hearing.

E. Courtesy Copies of Case Law and Other Documents

- **When Required:** Any materials that you would like the judge to consider prior to a hearing, including case law, memoranda of law, or evidence agreed to by opposing counsel, may be emailed to OCJudge2@circuit19.org in advance of the hearing and copied to opposing counsel. The Court does not require a formal memorandum to be submitted and highlighted cases or an outline of caselaw is permissible.

- **Format:** PDF, highlighted as needed

- **Submission Method:** OCJudge2@circuit19.org

- **Deadline for Submissions:** Courtesy copies are preferred be delivered to the court 3-business days before any evidentiary proceeding, or as soon after that as is practicable.

F. Emergency and Other Urgent Matters

- **Requirements:** If an emergency situation arises, counsel may request that a hearing be set on short notice. The body of the motion must contain a detailed explanation of the circumstances constituting the emergency as well as the substance of the motion. The motion must be emailed to the Court (OCJudge2@circuit19.org) before a hearing will be set.

- **Scheduling:** The Court will review the motion and, if it is determined an emergency exists, the JA will contact counsel to set the hearing. Please do not contact the JA for a status, the emergency motion will be responded to timely, as is possible.

G. Exhibits for Evidentiary Proceedings

- **Submission Method:** OCJudge2@circuit19.org

- **Format:** Exhibits must be submitted to the clerk of court in paper format – counsel should contact Clerk for proper form. All attorneys and self-represented litigants must bring sufficient copies of each exhibit for the clerk, the court, and each party to review during the hearing or trial. Exhibits must be labeled in the format required by the Clerk of Court.

- **Deadline for Submissions:** Evidence may be submitted during the hearing or trial. If the parties agree that the Court may view evidence prior to a hearing (such as a video or transcript), such evidence may be emailed to the Court in advance of the hearing and copied to opposing counsel at OCJudge2@circuit19.org. The Court will make its best efforts to review any agreed evidence submitted in advance as to make efficient use of time during the hearing.

H. Pretrial Procedures and Conferences

- **Case Management Conference and Status Conference:** The Court will place the case on a Case Management Conference (CMC) once its ready to be set for trial by an order. If a specific case management conference is requested earlier, then such request can be made via email at OCJudge2@circuit19.org. Any party may schedule a status conference when a case requires one.

- **Scheduling:** Pretrial Motions. All pretrial motions shall be filed at least

10 days prior to trial. The motion should be e-filed with the Clerk prior to scheduling your motion.

I. Setting Case for Trial

- **Procedure:** Mediation must have occurred and a notice for trial must be filed. The Court will review the case then place on a CMC docket and then given a trial date.

J. Forms

- **Access:** See website for forms

- **Usage:** Division forms must be used for all relevant filings.

K. Other Division Procedures

- **Certificates of Service:** Your certificate of service must be complete. Make sure that you include all parties and their central eservice addresses.

- **GOOD FAITH CERTIFICATE:** Notices of Hearings and Ex-Parte Motions **MUST** contain a **GOOD FAITH CERTIFICATION, stating the following,** "I certify that prior to filing this motion, I discussed the relief requested in this motion by [method of communication and date] with the opposing party and [the opposing party (agrees or disagrees) on the resolution of all or part of the motion] OR [the opposing party did not respond (describing with particularity all of the efforts undertaken to accomplish dialogue with the opposing party prior to filing the motion)]."

- **ADA Accommodations:** If you need an ADA accommodation, please contact Court Administration at 772-807-4370 Court Administration - Circuit19

- **Interpreter Requests:** If an interpreter is needed for a hearing or trial, please contact Court Administration. Visit the Circuit website for further information: Court Interpreters - Circuit19

- **Court Technology:** Please visit the Circuit website for further information: Technology - Circuit19

Judge Mullins' Zoom Information

Link: https://zoom.us/j/3397470884

Meeting ID: 339 747 0884

ZOOM BEHAVIOR

DO:

✓CONNECT EARLY: Appear for your hearing 10 minutes early. You will be in the virtual waiting room until you or your case is called.
✓IDENTIFY YOURSELF: Rename yourself on Zoom to show your actual name.
✓DRESS APPROPRIATELY: All participants must be fully dressed in proper courtroom attire—no pajamas, sunglasses or hats.
✓ACT AS IF YOU WERE AT THE COURTHOUSE: Behave as if you were attending Court in person. The same rules that apply to a live hearing in the courtroom apply to virtual hearings.
✓BE PREPARED: Have pen and paper readily accessible to write down important dates, times, and information regarding your case. You may also want a calendar to coordinate future Court appearances.
✓SPEAK TO THE CAMERA: When speaking, try to look directly at the webcam, not the screen. Position your camera at eye level and be mindful of what is behind you (as it will be visible to everyone).
✓BE ALONE: Remain seated in one quiet space, without anyone else present. If someone walks in, identify them immediately.
✓STAY MUTED: Mute yourself when you are not speaking to avoid background noise.
✓STAY QUIET: Participants should speak one at a time and pause prior to speaking in the event that there is video/audio lag.
✓PRACTICE: Become familiar with & practice Zooming prior to your hearing. Learn to connect your audio and check your lighting. To testify, you must appear by both VIDEO AND AUDIO so be familiar with both functions.

DON'T:

✓NO gum, no eating, no smoking or vaping.
✓NO minor children. Minors are NOT permitted to attend or be present in the room where any participant is attending Court. Persons with minor children should take all reasonable steps to ensure they are not exposed to the proceedings.
✓TURN OFF any electronic devices, especially phone ringer/notifications/alerts; do not communicate during the proceeding without the Court's permission and do not record the proceedings.
✓NO DRIVING: You must not attend or observe court proceedings while driving or operating heavy machinery. Your full attention is required.